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copyable_function

Abstract

This paper proposes a replacement for function in the form of a copyable variant of move_only_function.

Tony Table

Before		Proposed	
auto lambda{[&]() /*const*/ { ... }};		auto lambda{[&]() /*const*/ { ... }};	
function<void(void)> func{lambda};	✓	copyable_function<void(void)> func0{lambda};	✓
const auto & ref{func};		const auto & ref0{func0};	
func();	✓	func0();	✓
ref();	✓	ref0(); //operator() is NOT const!	✗
		copyable_function<void(void) const> func1{lambda};	✓
		const auto & ref1{func1};	
		func1();	✓
		ref1(); //operator() is const!	✓
auto lambda{[&]() mutable { ... }};		auto lambda{[&]() mutable { ... }};	
function<void(void)> func{lambda};	✓	copyable_function<void(void)> func{lambda};	✓
const auto & ref{func};		const auto & ref{func};	
func();	✓	func();	✓
ref(); //operator() is const!	✗	ref(); //operator() is NOT const!	✗
//this is the infamous constness-bug	✓		
		copyable_function<void(void) const> tmp{lambda};	✗

Revisions

R0: Initial version

R1:

- Incorporated the changes proposed for move_only_function in [\[P2511R2\]](#).
- Added wording for conversions from copyable_function to move_only_function.

R2:

- Removed changes adopted from [\[P2511R2\]](#) as that proposal didn't reach consensus in the 2022-10 LEWG electronic polling.

R3: Updates after LEWG Review on 2022-11-08:

- Fixed requirements on callables in the design section – copy-construct-ability is sufficient.

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- Removed open question on the deprecation of `function`.
- Replaced previously proposed conversion operators to `move_only_function`.
- Added section on conversions between standard library polymorphic function wrappers.
- Added section on potential allocator support.

R4: Updates after LEWG Review on 2022-11-11:

- Removed mandatory optimization for conversion to `move_only_function`.

R5: Updates after LEWG Review on 2023-03-07:

- Added section on naming of this class.
- Extended wording with recommended practice to avoid double wrapping of type-erased function wrappers.
- Fixed some wording bugs.

Motivation

C++11 added `function`, a type-erased function wrapper that can represent any *copyable* callable matching the function signature `R(Args...)`. Since its introduction, there have been identified several issues – including the infamous constness-bug – with its design (see [\[N4159\]](#)).

[\[P0288R9\]](#) introduced `move_only_function`, a *move-only* type-erased callable wrapper. In addition to dropping the *copyable* requirement, `move_only_function` extends the supported signature to `R(Args...) constop (&|&&)op noexceptop` and forwards all qualifiers to its call operator, introduces a strong non-empty precondition for invocation instead of throwing `bad_function_call` and drops the dependency to typeid/RTTI (there is no equivalent to function's `target_type()` or `target()`).

Concurrently, [\[P0792R10\]](#) introduced `function_ref`, a type-erased non-owning reference to any callable matching a function signature in the form of `R(Args...) constop noexceptop`. Like `move_only_function`, it forwards the `noexcept`-qualifier to its call operator. As `function_ref` acts like a reference, it does not support ref-qualifiers and does not forward the `const`-qualifier to its call operator.

As a result, `function` is now the only type-erased function wrapper not supporting any form of qualifiers in its signature. Whilst amending `function` with support for ref/noexcept-qualifiers would be a straightforward extension, the same is not true for the `const`-qualifier due to the long-standing constness-bug. Without proper support for the `const`-qualifier, `function` would still be inconsistent with its closest relative.

Therefore, this paper proposes to introduce a replacement to `function` in the form of `copyable_function`, a class that closely mirrors the design of `move_only_function` and adds *copyability* as an additional affordance.

Design space

The main goal of this paper is consistency between the *move-only* and *copyable* type-erased function wrappers. Therefore, we follow the design of `move_only_function` very closely and only introduce three extensions:

1. Adding a copy constructor
2. Adding a copy assignment operator
3. Requiring callables to be copy-constructible

Conversions between function wrappers

Given the proliferation of proposals for polymorphic function wrappers, LEWG requested an evaluation of the “conversion story” of these types. Note that conversions from `function_ref` always follow reference semantics for obvious reasons.

		To			
		function	move_only_function	copyable_function	function_ref
From	function		✓	✓	✓
	move_only_function	✗		✗	✓
	copyable_function	✓	✓		✓
	function_ref	✓	✓	✓	

It is recommended that implementors do not perform additional allocations when converting from a `copyable_function` instantiation to a compatible `move_only_function` instantiation, but this is left as quality-of-implementation.

Concerning allocator support

After having reviewed R2, LEWG requested a statement about potential allocator support. As this proposal aims for feature parity with `move_only_function` (apart from the extensions mentioned above) and considering the somewhat recent removal of allocator support from `function` [P0302], we refrain from adding allocator support to `copyable_function`. We welcome an independent paper introducing said support to both classes.

Naming discussion

During the review of R4, there were questions raised for the rationale for the name `copyable_function`, especially as it was perceived inconsistent with `move_only_function`. Our rationale for the name is as follows: `copyable_function` is a *copyable* function call wrapper that requires the target object to be *copyable*, so the `copyable`-prefix references both aspects. Furthermore, there isn't actually an inconsistency with `move_only_function`, as the `move_only`-prefix only applies to the wrapper; the wrapper is *move-only*, but there is no reason to require the target object to be as well.

Impact on the Standard

This proposal is a pure library addition.

Implementation Experience

The proposed design has been implemented at <https://github.com/MFHava/P2548>.

Proposed Wording

Wording is relative to [N4928]. Additions are presented like **this**, removals like **this** and drafting notes like **this**.

[version.syn]

```
#define cpp lib copyable function YYYYMM //also in <functional>
[DRAFTING NOTE: Adjust the placeholder value as needed to denote this proposal's date of adoption.]
```

[functional.syn]

22.10.2 Header <functional> synopsis

[functional.syn]

```
namespace std {
...
// [func.wrap.move], move only wrapper
template<class... S> class move_only_function; // not defined
template<class R, class... ArgTypes>
    class move_only_function<R(ArgTypes...) cv ref noexcept(noex)>; // see below

// [func.wrap.copy], copyable wrapper
template<class... S> class copyable_function; // not defined
template<class R, class... ArgTypes>
    class copyable_function<R(ArgTypes...) cv ref noexcept(noex)>; // see below

// [func.search], searchers
template<class ForwardIterator, class BinaryPredicate = equal_to>>
    class default_searcher;
...
}
```

[func.wrap.general]

22.10.17.1 General

[func.wrap.general]

1 Subclause [func.wrap] describes polymorphic wrapper classes that encapsulate arbitrary callable objects.

2 Recommended practice: Implementations should avoid double erasure when constructing polymorphic wrappers from one another

[DRAFTING NOTE: It's the intended design that moves can be elided, even if they would be observable when double wrapping:

```
move_only_function<void(T)> f(copyable_function<void(T)>{[](T) {}});
T t;
f(t); //may move t ones (unwrapping case) or twice (wrapping case) - both are acceptable.
]
```

22.10.17.2 Class bad_function_call

[func.wrap.badcall]

[func.wrap.copy]

[DRAFTING NOTE: Add a new section in [func.wrap]]

22.10.17.?? Copyable wrapper

[func.wrap.copy]

22.10.17.??1 General

[func.wrap.copy.general]

2 The header provides partial specializations of copyable_function for each combination of the possible replacements of the placeholders cv, ref, and noex where

(1.1) — cv is either const or empty,

(1.2) — ref is either &, &&, or empty, and

(1.3) — noex is either true or false.

2 For each of the possible combinations of the placeholders mentioned above, there is a placeholder inv-quals defined as follows:

(2.1) — If ref is empty, let inv-quals be cv&.

(2.2) — otherwise, let inv-quals be cv_ref.

22.10.17.??2 Class template copyable_function

[func.wrap.copy.class]

```
namespace std {
    template<class... S> class copyable_function; // not defined

    template<class R, class... ArgTypes>
        class copyable_function<R(ArgTypes...) cv ref noexcept(noex)> {
        public:
            using result_type = R;

            // [func.wrap.copy.ctor], constructors, assignments, and destructors
            copyable_function() noexcept;
            copyable_function(nullptr t) noexcept;
            copyable_function(const copyable_function&);
            copyable_function(copyable_function&&) noexcept;
            template<class F> copyable_function(F&&);
            template<class T, class... Args>
                explicit copyable_function(in place type t<T>, Args&&...);
            template<class T, class U, class... Args>
                explicit copyable_function(in place type t<T>, initializer list<U>, Args&&...);

            copyable_function& operator=(const copyable_function&);
            copyable_function& operator=(copyable_function&&);
            copyable_function& operator=(nullptr t) noexcept;
            template<class F> copyable_function& operator=(F&&);

            ~copyable_function();

            // [func.wrap.copy.inv], invocation
            explicit operator bool() const noexcept;
            R operator()(ArgTypes...) cv ref noexcept(noex);
        };
}
```

```

// [func.wrap.copy.util], utility
void swap(copyable function&) noexcept;
friend void swap(copyable function&, copyable function&) noexcept;
friend bool operator==(const copyable function&, nullptr t) noexcept;

private:
    template<class VT>
        static constexpr bool is-callable-from = see below; //exposition only
};

```

1 The copyable function class template provides polymorphic wrappers that generalize the notion of a callable object ([func.def]). These wrappers can store, copy, move, and call arbitrary callable objects, given a call signature. Within this subclause, *call-args* is an argument pack with elements that have types *ArgTypes*&&... respectively.

2 *Recommended practice:* Implementations should avoid the use of dynamically allocated memory for a small contained value.
[Note 1: Such small-object optimization can only be applied to a type *T* for which *is_nothrow_constructible_v<T>* is true. — end note]

22.10.17.??3 Constructors, assignment, and destructor [func.wrap.copy.ctor]

```

template<class VT>
    static constexpr bool is-callable-from = see below;

1   If noex is true, is-callable-from<VT> is equal to:
        is_nothrow_invocable_r v<R, VT cv ref, ArgTypes...> &&
        is_nothrow_invocable_r v<R, VT inv-quals, ArgTypes...>
    Otherwise, is-callable-from<VT> is equal to:
        is_invocable_r v<R, VT cv ref, ArgTypes...> &&
        is_invocable_r v<R, VT inv-quals, ArgTypes...>

```

```

copyable function() noexcept;
copyable function(nullptr t) noexcept;
2   Postconditions: *this has no target object

```

```

copyable function(const copyable function& f)
3   Postconditions: *this has no target object if f had no target object.
    Otherwise, the target object of *this is a copy of the target object of f.
4   Throws: Any exception thrown by the initialization of the target object. May throw bad_alloc.

```

```

copyable function(copyable function&& f) noexcept;
5   Postconditions: The target object of *this is the target object f had before construction, and f is in a valid state with an unspecified value.

```

```

6   template<class F> copyable function(F&& f):
7   Let VT be decay t<F>.
8   Constraints:
9.1  — remove_cvref t<F> is not the same as copyable function, and
9.2  — remove_cvref t<F> is not a specialization of in place type t, and
9.3  — is-callable-from<VT> is true.
10  Mandates:
10.1 — is_constructible v<VT, F> is true, and
10.2 — is_copy_constructible v<VT> is true.
11  Preconditions: VT meets the Cpp17Destructible and Cpp17CopyConstructible requirements.
12  Postconditions: *this has no target object if any of the following hold:
13.1 — f is a null function pointer value, or
13.2 — f is a null member function pointer value, or
13.3 — remove_cvref t<F> is a specialization of the copyable function class template, and f has no target object.
14  Otherwise, *this has a target object of type VT direct-non-list-initialized with std::forward<F>(f).
15  Throws: Any exception thrown by the initialization of the target object. May throw bad_alloc unless VT is a function pointer or a specialization of reference wrapper.

```

```

16  template<class T, class... Args>
17  explicit copyable function(in place type t<T>, Args&&... args):
18  Let VT be decay t<T>.
19  Constraints:
19.1 — is_constructible v<VT, Args...> is true, and
19.2 — is-callable-from<VT> is true.
20  Mandates:
20.1 — VT is the same type as T, and
20.2 — is_copy_constructible v<VT> is true.
21  Preconditions: VT meets the Cpp17Destructible and Cpp17CopyConstructible requirements.
22  Postconditions: *this has a target object d of type VT direct-non-list-initialized with std::forward<Args>(args)...
23  Throws: Any exception thrown by the initialization of the target object. May throw bad_alloc unless VT is a pointer or a specialization of reference wrapper.

```

```

24  template<class T, class U, class... Args>
25  explicit copyable function(in place type t<T>, initializer list<U> ilist, Args&&... args):
26  Let VT be decay t<T>.

```

```

19 Constraints:
19.1 — is_constructible v<VT, initializer_list<U>&, Args...> is true, and
19.2 — is_callable_from<VT> is true.
20 Mandates:
20.1 — VT is the same type as T, and
20.2 — is_copy_constructible v<VT> is true.
21 Preconditions: VT meets the Cpp17Destructible and Cpp17CopyConstructible requirements.
22 Postconditions: *this has a target object d of type VT direct-non-list-initialized with ilist, std::forward<Args>(args)...
23 Throws: Any exception thrown by the initialization of the target object. May throw bad_alloc unless VT is a pointer or a specialization of reference_wrapper.

copyable function& operator=(const copyable function& f);
24 Effects: Equivalent to: copyable_function(f).swap(*this);
25 Returns: *this.

copyable function& operator=(copyable function&& f);
26 Effects: Equivalent to: copyable_function(std::move(f)).swap(*this);
27 Returns: *this.

copyable function& operator=(nullptr_t) noexcept;
28 Effects: Destroys the target object of *this, if any.
29 Returns: *this.

template<class F> copyable function& operator=(F&& f);
30 Effects: Equivalent to: copyable_function(std::forward<F>(f)).swap(*this);
31 Returns: *this.

~copyable_function();
32 Effects: Destroys the target object of *this, if any.

22.10.17.??4 Invocation [func.wrap.copy.inv]
explicit operator bool() const noexcept;
1 Returns: true if *this has a target object, otherwise false.

R operator()(ArgTypes... args) cv ref noexcept(noex);
2 Preconditions: *this has a target object.
3 Effects: Equivalent to:
return INVOKE<R>(static_cast<F inv-quals>(f), std::forward<ArgTypes>(args)...);
where f is an lvalue designating the target object of *this and F is the type of f.

22.10.17.??5 Utility [func.wrap.copy.util]
void swap(copyable function& other) noexcept;
4 Effects: Exchanges the target objects of *this and other.

friend void swap(copyable function& f1, copyable function& f2) noexcept;
5 Effects: Equivalent to f1.swap(f2).

friend bool operator==(const copyable function& f, nullptr_t) noexcept;
6 Returns: true if f has no target object, otherwise false.

```

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